

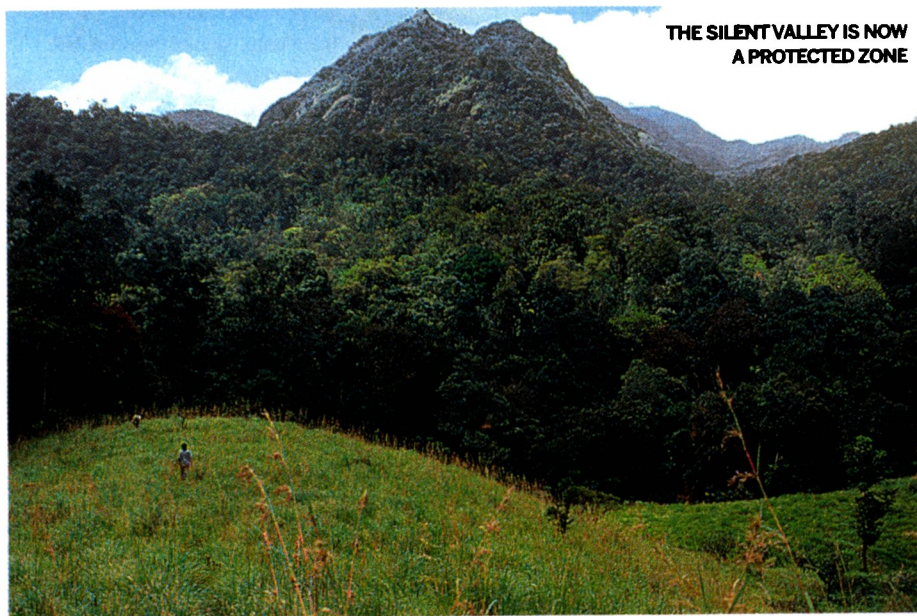
|1976| SILENT VALLEY MOVEMENT

The Genesis of Green

It became the bedrock of environmental agitations across the country

When the Kerala State Electricity Board announced plans to begin the construction of a 240 MW hydroelectric project over the Kunthipuzha river flowing through the Palakkad and Mallapuram districts in 1976, it triggered a wave of protests across the state. Soon it became India's first major environmental movement resulting in far-reaching changes in the way the nation cleared infrastructure projects. The protesters, spear-headed by the Kerala Shastra Sahitya Parishad, a voluntary organisation to promote scientific temperament, produced hard facts. It showed the enormous damage the project would cause by submerging 530 hectare of pristine evergreen forests rich in biodiversity. Known as the Silent Valley, a misnomer because the dense forests are teeming with life, it was one of the world's ecological hotspots. The Valley harboured a range of species endemic to the region, including the lion-tailed macaque, that faced the threat of extinction. In 1980, the then prime minister Indira Gandhi told the state government to abandon the project. She declared the area a National Park and by 1984 the necessary legislation was in place to ensure that status. The agitation led to the establishment of stringent clearances including a mandatory environmental impact assessment report to be submitted to the Central Government for clearance of any major project that had ecological implications. The success of the 'Save Silent Valley' movement became the inspiration for similar agitations, including the Narmada Bachao Andolan and protests against the Tehri Dam. Today, the virgin forests and the unparalleled beauty of the park bear silent testimony to what a determined band of environmentally conscious individuals can achieve if they combine forces.

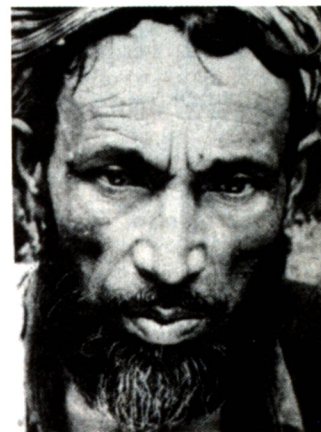
by Raj Chengappa



THE SILENT VALLEY IS NOW
A PROTECTED ZONE

THE MAIN EVENT

Forced Family Planning



46-YEAR-OLD MOHAMMED BASTUR,
A DAILY LABOURER WHO WAS
FORCIBLY STERILISED

"When the burkha-clad women of our area thought things were getting out of hand," said Z. Ahmed, 37, a cloth merchant of Jama Masjid, "they organised a protest march. And they were beaten mercilessly by the police. It is then that Rukhsana Sultan ordered the bulldozers on Turkman Gate. She collected all the *goondas* of the area to threaten residents into either vacating their houses or getting themselves sterilised. Her *goondas* made so much money during the Emergency that they used to drink every night and misbehave."

India Today, May 31, 1977

ALSO

- The age for marriage in India is raised to 21 for men and 18 for women
- Amritsar-Lahore Express becomes the first train from India to Pakistan after rail links were snapped during Partition
- Parveen Babi makes it to the cover of *Time* magazine

Manual Cow-milking

Machines The low-cost home-made machine is a steal for the 250 million Indian cattle.

Jugaad

The locally improvised rural transport vehicle runs on irrigation pumpsets used by farmers.

Simputers

These simple computers running on open hardware are bridging the digital divide in India.

Low-cost Sanitary

Napkins A Tamil Nadu entrepreneur's innovation rolls out 1,000 pieces, at Rs 2 a piece.

Artificial Weather

Stations They are satellite-linked weather monitoring and data sharing systems.